

Learner-training worksheet 1

Being an active learner

- 1 Read about four different students of English below and number them 1–3 according to how successful you think they will be in learning English (1 = most successful, 3 = least successful).

BERNARD



Bernard takes learning English very seriously. He's particularly keen on English grammar – he spends many hours at home studying grammar books and doing exercises. In class, he always has lots of questions for his teacher – in fact he knows so much about grammar that sometimes his teacher finds it hard to answer! Bernard is also keen to learn vocabulary – he always has his bilingual dictionary next to him in class, and looks up any new words he meets. He prefers this to listening to the teacher's explanations, because he likes to have an exact translation of things. At home, as well as doing his homework and studying his grammar books, he spends twenty minutes every day studying lists of new vocabulary that he has learnt. He quite enjoys his English lessons, but he feels that his teacher wastes too much time on groupwork. He doesn't like speaking to other students – they don't speak English well enough, and he doesn't like making mistakes that the teacher can't correct. So usually during these parts of the lesson, he reads one of his grammar books, or looks through the dictionary – he feels he's learning more this way. ☐

GABRIELA



Gabriela really enjoys her English lessons, though she's very busy in her job and doesn't always have enough time to study. She likes her teacher and her classmates, and enjoys speaking English, both with the teacher and with other students. She always tries to say as much as she can, even if the topic is not something that really interests her – it's still good practice. If there's something she wants to express or doesn't understand, she asks her teacher for the right word. She tries to correct herself and to use new words that she has learnt, but she doesn't worry too much if she makes mistakes. She knows she often gets things wrong, but she believes that you have to make mistakes in order to learn. Gabriela's fairly good at grammar – when she meets new grammar, she tries to work out the rules for herself, but of course she's not always right! Outside her lessons she doesn't always manage to do all her homework, but she does try to do it as carefully as possible, reading it through, and trying to correct the mistakes before she hands it in. Apart from that, she sometimes gets the chance to practise her English at work, when she meets English-speaking colleagues from the international offices of her company. She really enjoys this and makes a special effort to chat to them, even if she sometimes feels a bit shy about the level of her English! ☐

GLORIA



Gloria doesn't really know why she's learning English, but perhaps it'll be useful some day. Anyway, her parents are paying a lot of money for her lessons so, as she sees it, it's her teacher's job to make sure that she learns. She tries to come to most of the lessons, but she's generally a bit late because she's been out dancing the night before, and when she does arrive, she often isn't feeling too good. Her teacher always explains new vocabulary and grammar in English, but Gloria doesn't usually listen very hard to these parts of the lesson – her friend Monica speaks much better English than she does, so she normally asks her to translate what the teacher's said. Sometimes the teacher asks her questions and expects her to answer in English, but the questions often don't interest her much, and anyway she's a bit shy about speaking English, so she usually just answers in one word, or looks at the floor until the teacher asks someone else. They have to do quite a lot of groupwork in her class too, but for Gloria this is a good chance to find out what her friends have been doing, so they usually have a good chat – not in English, obviously! ☐

2 Compare answers with other students. Make a list of the habits and attitudes that you think will / won't make each student successful, and discuss the reasons why.

3 Read an analysis below of how successful the three students are likely to be. Were you surprised by anything you read?

What are their chances of success?

Both Bernard and Gabriela have some very positive attitudes. In particular they take an active approach to their studies – they understand that they will only progress if they take responsibility for learning. Their teacher cannot 'wave a magic wand' over them and make them learn English!

Bernard spends a lot of time studying outside the lesson, which is very good, and asks lots of questions, which is also good. Nevertheless, he may not be spending his time in the best possible way – of course, grammar and vocabulary are important, but just as important is to use what you know, whether in the classroom during groupwork, or outside. Perhaps he should take his nose out of his grammar books sometimes and go and see a film in English or, if possible, try to meet some English-speaking people.

In the end Gabriela, may actually be more successful than Bernard for this very reason. Although she feels that she doesn't spend enough time studying at home, she has a very positive attitude during lessons. She takes every opportunity to speak, asking for the words she needs to express what she wants to say, and trying to use the best English she can without worrying too much if she makes mistakes. She should do very well.

As for Gloria – what is there to say? Her English is never going to improve unless she changes her attitude! She may have a busy social life, but at least she could make better use of her time during her lessons! If she tries to answer questions in more than three words, starts listening to her teacher instead of her friend, and makes an effort to speak English rather than her own language, she should soon enjoy her classes more, become a lot more confident and start to make some progress!

4 Discuss the following questions in pairs, or think about them individually.

- a The article mentions the importance of an 'active approach' to learning. Is there anything you could do to take a more active approach? Make three 'resolutions' to help you to become a more successful learner of English – but remember to be realistic about what you can do!
- b Are there any ways in which you would like your teacher to help you?